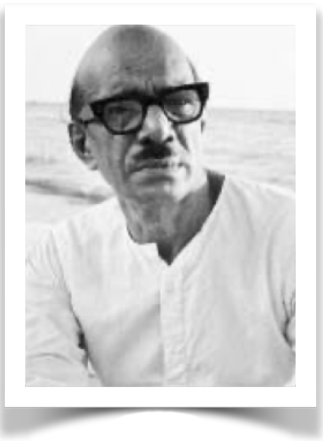
The World-Renowned Nose

Vaikom Muhammad Basheer

About the Author



Vaikom Muhammad Basheer (1908–1994) is one of the most celebrated writers in Malayalam literature and an important voice in modern Indian writing. A freedom fighter, humanist, and ardent follower of Mahatma Gandhi, he actively participated in the Indian independence movement and was imprisoned for his political activities. His varied life experiences deeply influenced his literary works. Basheer's writing is admired for its simplicity, conversational style, gentle humour, and profound understanding of human nature. He often portrayed the lives of common people with empathy while exposing social contradictions through satire and irony. His notable works include *Balyakalasakhi*, *Pathummayude Aadu*, *Premalekhanam*, *Mathilukal*, and *Shabdangal*. He received the Padma Shri and the Kerala Sahitya Akademi Fellowship for his outstanding contribution to Indian literature.

About the Story



"The World-Renowned Nose" (*Vishwavikhyathamaya Mookku*), first published in 1954, is one of Vaikom Muhammad Basheer's finest satirical short stories. The narrative revolves around an ordinary, illiterate cook whose nose mysteriously grows until it reaches his navel. What begins as a physical oddity soon transforms him into an international celebrity, attracting the attention of the public, the media, politicians, and intellectuals. Through this absurd yet entertaining premise, Basheer exposes society's obsession with spectacle, fame, and sensationalism. The story also critiques political opportunism, media manipulation, and the public's tendency to value appearances over humanity. Combining humour, irony, exaggeration, and symbolism, Basheer creates a timeless satire that remains remarkably relevant in the age of viral fame, misinformation, and celebrity culture.

The Text: *The World-Renowned Nose*

It is sensational news. A nose has become a topic of controversy among intellectuals and political thinkers. A world-renowned nose!

I record here the true story of that nose.

The owner of that world-renowned nose had completed twenty-four years of age when the story began. No one knew him before that. Does the twenty-fourth year in a person's life have any special significance? Who knows? If one looks through the recorded pages of world history one finds that the twenty-fourth year had a significance in many great lives. Students of history need hardly be told this.

The hero of our story was a cook, a kitchen worker if you like. He was not particularly intelligent. He could not read and write. His world was confined to the kitchen. He was totally indifferent to happenings outside the kitchen. Why should he pay attention to them? He could eat to his satisfaction; take as much snuff as he wanted, sleep, work. His daily routine was confined to these activities.

He did not know the names of the months of the year. When it was time for him to receive his salary, his mother would come and collect it. If he wanted snuff the old woman herself would buy it for him. He lived a contented life till he reached his twenty-fourth year. Then an amazing thing happened!

His nose grew slightly in length. It passed his mouth and reached the level of his chin. The nose began to grow in length every day. Was it possible to hide this? Within a month the nose reached his navel. Did he feel uncomfortable? Not in the least! He could breathe freely. He could inhale snuff. He could distinguish between smells. There was no inconvenience worth talking about.

However, because of his nose the poor cook was dismissed from his work. What was the reason?

No group came forward with the battle cry, 'Take back the dismissed employee.' Political parties shut their eyes to this piece of blatant injustice.

'Why was this man dismissed?' No lover of humanity came forward with this query.

The poor cook!

No one needed to tell him why he had lost his job. The reason was that the people living in the house where he worked could find no peace or quiet because of him. People came visiting night and day to see the long-nosed one and his nose. Photographers pestered them. News reporters became a 'nuisance. A number of things were pilfered from the house.

As the dismissed cook sat starving in his lowly hut, he was convinced of one thing—his nose had acquired great publicity!

People from distant lands came to see him. They stood stunned with surprise at his long nose. Some touched it too. But no one asked, 'Have you eaten today? Why do you look so weak?" There was money in the hut not even to buy a small packet of snuff. Was he a wild animal to be kept starving? He might be a fool, but he was a human being. One day he called his old mother aside and told her in a whisper, 'Get these horrid people out and shut the door!'

The mother promptly sent them all out and closed the door.

Good fortune came to the mother and son from that day. People began to bribe the mother to see the son's nose! Some upholders of justice protested against this corruption. But the Government did not take any action. Many protested against the inaction of the Government and joined revolutionary Parties out to sabotage the Government!

The income of the long-nosed one grew day by day. Need one say more? In six years, the poor cook became a millionaire.

He acted in films thrice. What vast audiences were attracted by the Technicolor feature film, "The Human Submarine'! Six poets wrote epic poems about the noble qualities of the long nosed one. Nine well-known writers wrote biographies of the long-nosed one and won wealth and acclaim.

His princely abode was also a guest-house open to all. Anyone at any time could get a meal there; and a bit of snuff.

He had two secretaries. Two comely, accomplished women.

Both of them loved the long-nosed one. Both of them worshipped him. When two beautiful women love the same man at the same time there is bound to be trouble. Troubles came into the life of the long-nosed one.

Other people also loved the long-nosed one; that long nose reaching down to the navel was considered a sign of greatness. The long-nosed one gave his opinion on important world events.

Newspapers published his comments:

'An aeroplane with a speed of 10,000 miles an hour has been built! The long- nosed one commented in this way on the event—!’

'Doctor Bundrose Furasiburose has brought a dead man to life! The long-nosed one made the following speech about it—!”

When people heard that the highest peak in the world had been scaled, they asked, 'What does the long-nosed one say about this?'

If the long-nosed one said nothing about an event.... *Poo*! It was unimportant. And also, the long-nosed one was expected to comment on anything and everything! Art, the watch trade, mesmerism, photography, the soul, publishing houses, the writing of novels, life after death, the conduct of newspapers, hunting.

It was at this time that conspiracies were hatched to capture the long-nosed one. To capture something, taking something by physical conquest, was nothing new. The major part of world history consists of conquests and captures.

What does it mean, to capture? Suppose you plant coconut seedlings: on a piece of barren land. You water the land and manure it. You fence it in. Expectant years slip by and the trees bear fruit. Coconuts hang in proud clusters from the palms. Then someone takes that garden away from you.

First of all, it was the Government that made an attempt to capture the long-nosed one. They tried a trick. The Government awarded him the title 'Chief of the Long- Nosed Ones 'and gave him a medal. It was the President himself who tied the jewelled gold medal round the neck of the long-nosed one. Then, instead of shaking the long-nosed one by the hand, the President tweaked the tip of the long nose. This was filmed by newsreel cameramen and shown in all the theatres.

By that time the political parties in the country had come forward enthusiastically. Comrade Long-Nose must give leadership to the people's struggle! Comrade Long-Nose indeed! Whose Comrade? Comrade in what? Great God! Poor long- nosed one!

The long-nosed one must join The Party! Which party? There were many parties. How could the long-nosed one join so many different parties at the same time?

The long-nosed one said in his own tongue, 'Why should I join a party or parties? Me, I am too tired.'

Then one of the secretaries said, 'If Comrade likes me, he must join my party.' The long-nosed one said nothing to that.

'Need I join any party?' the long-nosed one asked the other secretary. She guessed what he was aiming at. She replied, 'Why should you?'

By that time one of the political parties had come out with the slogan: 'Our party is the long-nosed one's party, the long-nosed one's party is the people's party!'

Members of other parties were incensed by this. They got at one of the secretaries and made her issue a scathing statement against the long-nosed one: 'The long- nosed one has deceived the people! He has been cheating them all this while. He has made me a partner in this fraud. Let me declare the truth to the public-the long nose is made of rubber!'

What a statement! All the newspapers splashed the news on their front pages. The nose of the long-nosed one is made of rubber! Would the people keep quiet at this? Would

they not react in rage? Cables, telephone calls and letters came from all parts of the world! The President was allowed no peace or quiet. 'Destruction to the rubber nose of the long-nosed one! Down with the Long-Nose Party! Long live revolution!

When the anti-Long-Nose Party put out this statement the opposing party made the other secretary issue a counterstatement: 'Beloved countrymen, citizens! What she has said is a lie. Comrade Long-Nose did not love her and this is her revenge. She was trying to keep for herself the wealth and good name of Comrade Long- Nose. One of her brothers is in the opposite party. Let me reveal the true colours of the members of the other party. I am the faithful secretary of Comrade Long- Nose. I know for a fact that the nose of the comrade is not made of rubber. It is as real as my own heart beating inside me. Long live the members of the party supporting Comrade Long-Nose at this critical time! They have no motives of gain other than the progress of the people. Long live revolution!'

What was to be done? There was confusion in the minds of the people. The leaders of the party against the long-nosed one began finding fault with the President and the Government. 'Stupid Government! They gave the title "Chief of the Long Nosed Ones" to a deceiver of the people. They gave him a jewelled gold medal. The President is also involved in this fraud. They have betrayed the national interest. The President must resign. The Ministry must resign! The rubber-nosed one must be killed!'

The President reacted angrily. One morning the army and their tanks surrounded the house of the poor long-nosed one. He was arrested and taken away.

There was no news of the long-nosed one for some time. The people forgot about his existence. Then came fresh news with the impact of a nuclear bomb! Do you know what happened? Just when the people had forgotten everything came a brief announcement from the President: 'The trial of the "Chief of the Long- Nosed Ones" will take place on 9 March. Expert doctors who come as representatives of forty-eight countries will examine him. All the newspapers of the world will be—represented by their respective correspondents. The proceedings will be filmed for all the world to see. The people must keep calm.'

People are people. They could not keep calm. They came in large numbers into the metropolis. They invaded the hotels. They burnt public conveyances. They set fire to police stations. They destroyed government buildings. There were communal riots. Quite a number of men and women died as martyrs in this fight for the long-nosed one.

9 March, 11 a.m. The square in front of the Presidential Palace was a vast sea of humanity. The loud speakers blared forth: 'People must be disciplined. The examination has begun!'

The doctors surrounded the long-nosed one in the presence of the President and cabinet ministers. One doctor blocked the nostrils of the long-nosed one; he immediately opened his mouth wide. Another doctor took a needle and punctured the tip of his nose. To his amazement a drop of blood appeared at the tip of the nose.

The doctors gave their unanimous verdict: 'The nose is not made of rubber. It is genuine.'

One of the female secretaries kissed the long-nosed one on the tip of the nose.

'Long live Comrade Long-Nose! Long live the "Chief of the Long-Nosed Ones"! Long live the Progressive People's Party of the long-nosed one!' As this shouting and revelry ended, the President thought of another gimmick. He nominated the longnosed one as a member of parliament! 'The Honourable Long Nose M.P!' Three universities conferred doctorates on him. "The Honourable Long Nose D. Lit!' The ignorant populace acclaimed the actions of the equally ignorant Government which ruled over them.

But the parties of which the long-nosed one was not a member formed a United Front and began to proclaim: "The Ministry must resign! This is a-fraud on the people! It's a rubber nose!"

Look at the way falsehood was being perpetuated! Would there not be confusion of thought? What could the poor intellectual do?

Summary of the Story

The World-Renowned Nose tells the story of an ordinary cook who leads a simple, contented life until his twenty-fourth year, when his nose begins to grow unusually long. Although the cook is not troubled by the strange change, people become fascinated by his appearance. Curious visitors, journalists, and photographers crowd around him, eventually causing him to lose his job. Ironically, while everyone is eager to see his extraordinary nose, no one cares about his poverty or hunger.

Realizing the public's curiosity, the cook's mother begins charging visitors to see her son. As a result, the once-poor cook becomes wealthy and famous. He appears in films, poets celebrate him, writers publish his biographies, and newspapers seek his opinions on every imaginable subject, despite his being illiterate. His fame soon attracts politicians, who attempt to use him for their own purposes. Rival political parties compete to claim him, while rumours spread that his famous nose is made of rubber. Public protests, political conflicts, and nationwide confusion follow, leading to the cook's arrest.

Eventually, a team of international doctors examines the nose and declares that it is genuine. Yet the controversy refuses to end, as political groups continue exploiting the issue for their own interests. Through this humorous and highly exaggerated narrative, Basheer satirizes the absurdity of fame, the sensationalism of the media, political manipulation, and the gullibility of the public. The story ultimately reminds readers that society often values spectacle more than truth or genuine human concern.

Major Characters

The story contains a number of characters:

The Cook (Protagonist)



The unnamed cook is an ordinary, illiterate, and contented man whose unusually long nose transforms him into an unexpected celebrity. Innocent and unambitious, he neither seeks fame nor understands the attention he receives. Through his character, Basheer portrays the exploitation of ordinary individuals by society, the media, and political institutions, making him both a comic figure and a sympathetic victim.

The Cook's Mother



The cook's mother is practical, resourceful, and protective. Recognizing the public's fascination with her son's nose, she begins charging visitors to see him, thereby improving their financial condition. Rather than being driven by greed, she responds pragmatically to changing circumstances. Her character reflects the resilience and survival instincts of ordinary people confronted with unexpected opportunities.

The Two Secretaries



The two secretaries, appointed to manage the cook's affairs, represent personal ambition, jealousy, and political manipulation. Their rivalry generates confusion and contributes to the public controversy surrounding the cook. Through them, Basheer satirizes those who exploit fame for personal gain and demonstrates how self-interest often overshadows truth and integrity.

The Public



The public functions as a collective character rather than a group of individuals. Curious, emotional, and easily influenced, people become obsessed with the cook's nose, spread rumours, and react irrationally to sensational news. Basheer uses the crowd to expose the dangers of mass hysteria, blind admiration, and the tendency to value spectacle over compassion and reason.

Politicians and Government

Political leaders and government officials are portrayed as opportunistic and theatrical. Initially indifferent to the cook's suffering, they become interested only after his fame grows. They exploit his popularity for political advantage, bestow honours upon him, and later arrest him when controversy arises. Through these characters, Basheer critiques politics driven by image, propaganda, and public spectacle rather than genuine public service.

The Media

Reporters, photographers, and newspapers play a crucial role in transforming the cook into a national celebrity. They sensationalize his condition, publish fabricated stories, and spread rumours without concern for truth or the cook's well-being. Basheer portrays the media as a powerful force capable of shaping public opinion, creating spectacles, and manipulating reality through selective reporting.

Major Themes

Absurdity of Fame

One of the central themes of the story is the irrational nature of fame. The cook becomes world-famous not because of talent, wisdom, or achievement, but simply because of his unusually long nose. Basheer satirizes a society that celebrates spectacle instead of substance, showing how popularity can arise from trivial or accidental circumstances rather than genuine merit.

Media Sensationalism

Basheer exposes the tendency of the media to transform ordinary events into sensational stories. Journalists and newspapers exaggerate the cook's condition, invent opinions on his behalf, and spread rumours that fuel public excitement. The story demonstrates how media can influence public perception by prioritizing entertainment over truth.

Political Opportunism

The story sharply criticizes politicians who exploit public sentiment for personal and political gain. Different political parties attempt to claim the cook as their own symbol, while government institutions use ceremonies and honours to create political spectacles. Basheer reveals how politics often values appearances and publicity more than genuine concern for individuals.

Public Gullibility and Mass Psychology

The public in the story is easily influenced by rumours, propaganda, and sensational news. People quickly believe false information, react emotionally, and even participate in riots without verifying facts. Basheer highlights the dangers of collective irrationality and the importance of critical thinking.

Identity and Exploitation

As the cook's fame grows, he gradually loses his personal identity. Society no longer sees him as an ordinary human being but only as "the man with the famous nose." Various groups—including the media, politicians, and the public—exploit him for their own purposes, illustrating how individuals can become commodities in a spectacle-driven society.

Appearance versus Reality

The contrast between outward appearance and inner reality runs throughout the story. Although the cook's nose attracts worldwide attention, his simple personality remains unchanged. Basheer reminds readers that society often judges people by superficial characteristics while ignoring their true humanity and dignity.

Basheer's Writing Style

Vaikom Muhammad Basheer's writing is distinguished by its remarkable simplicity, conversational tone, and deep humanity. He employs humour, irony, satire, and exaggeration to explore serious social and political issues without becoming preachy. His language is accessible and rooted in everyday speech, making his works appealing to a wide readership. Basheer often presents extraordinary events in a calm, matter-of-fact manner, creating a distinctive deadpan humour that heightens the impact of his satire. Through ordinary characters and seemingly absurd situations, he reveals profound truths about human nature and society.

Relevance of the Story Today

Although *The World-Renowned Nose* was written in 1954, its relevance has only increased in the modern world. The story anticipates many contemporary phenomena, including viral fame, influencer culture, fake news, media sensationalism, political propaganda, and public obsession with spectacle. Like the cook, many people today become famous overnight for accidental or trivial reasons, while misinformation spreads rapidly through digital media.

Basheer's satire encourages readers to question public narratives, think critically about media representations, and recognize how individuals and institutions can manipulate public opinion. The story ultimately reminds us to value truth, humanity, and reason over popularity, appearances, and sensationalism, making it as meaningful today as it was when it was first published.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. What is the main reason for the cook's sudden fame in the story?

A. He writes a famous book.
B. He delivers a powerful political speech.
C. His nose grows unusually long.
D. He wins a national award.

2. Which institution is most sharply criticized for turning the cook into a public spectacle?

A. The educational system
B. The media
C. The judiciary
D. The military

3. What does the extraordinarily long nose primarily symbolize in the story?

A. Physical strength and courage
B. Society's obsession with fame and spectacle
C. Scientific progress and innovation
D. Religious devotion

4. Which of the following best describes the character of the cook?

A. Ambitious, educated, and politically active
B. Wealthy, influential, and manipulative
C. Innocent, simple, and easily exploited
D. Proud, arrogant, and power-hungry

5. How does Basheer mainly criticize politics in *The World-Renowned Nose*?

A. By portraying politicians as heroic leaders
B. By showing political parties exploiting the cook's fame for their own interests
C. By encouraging citizens to participate in elections
D. By describing detailed government policies

6. Which literary device is most prominently employed throughout *The World-Renowned Nose*?

A. Tragedy
B. Romanticism
C. Satire combined with humour and exaggeration
D. Detective fiction

Answer Keys: 1. C; 2. B; 3. B; 4. C; 5. B; 6. C.

Short Answer Questions

1. How does Basheer use the cook's long nose to satirize society?

Answer Hint: The long nose symbolizes society's obsession with sensationalism and fame. Basheer shows how ordinary people can become famous for trivial reasons while society ignores genuine human concerns.

2. Explain the role of the media in shaping the cook's public image.

Answer Hint: The media sensationalizes the cook's unusual nose, spreads exaggerated stories and rumours, and transforms him into a celebrity. Basheer critiques the media's tendency to prioritize spectacle over truth.

3. Discuss how political parties exploit the cook in the story.

Answer Hint: Political parties attempt to use the cook's popularity for their own benefit, treating him as a political symbol rather than as a person. This exposes political opportunism and manipulation.

4. Describe the character of the cook. Why is he an effective protagonist for the story?

Answer Hint: The cook is simple, innocent, contented, and unambitious. His ordinary nature contrasts with the extraordinary attention he receives, making him an effective vehicle for Basheer's social satire.

5. Why is *The World-Renowned Nose* still relevant in today's world?

Answer Hint: The story remains relevant because it reflects contemporary issues such as viral fame, media sensationalism, misinformation, political propaganda, and society's fascination with spectacle. It encourages readers to think critically about how public opinion is shaped.

Essay Questions with Answer Hints

1. Discuss *The World-Renowned Nose* as a satire on modern society. How does Vaikom Muhammad Basheer criticize the media, politics, and public behaviour through the story?

Answer Hint: Explain how Basheer uses the absurd growth of the cook's nose to expose society's obsession with fame and spectacle. Discuss the role of the media in creating sensational news, the exploitation of the cook by political parties, the public's gullibility, and the use of humour, irony, and exaggeration to critique contemporary social and political realities.

2. Examine the symbolism of the nose in *The World-Renowned Nose*. How does Basheer use this central symbol to explore themes such as fame, identity, and human values?

Answer Hint: Discuss the nose as a symbol of accidental fame and social spectacle rather than personal merit. Explain how the cook loses his identity as an individual and becomes known only for his unusual nose. Relate the symbol to the themes of media sensationalism, political manipulation, superficial judgments, and the contrast between appearance and reality. Conclude by commenting on the continuing relevance of the story in the age of social media and viral celebrity culture.